Peter Polner

Prof. Leung

ENGL101

March 30, 2024

Daniel Plainview's Sociopathy and Greed

In the 2008 drama film *There Will Be Blood* the main character, the oil prospector Daniel Plainview uses theatrics and manipulation to keep power within his hands. The film focuses on Plainview seizing control of a small Californian town, due to the discovery of oil, the only stipulation being that he has to support the local church controlled by the equally ambitious Eli Sunday. This leads to a clash towards the final leg of the film where in his untruthful public confession Daniel undermines the power dynamic between him and Eli by making it seem as if he is submissive to the power of the church which he is not, showing his manipulating ways in which he succeeds, so that others won't. This manipulation is shown throughout the film, by first using an orphan he adopted to seem like a family oil operation and to gain the trust of various local towns to prospect for oil. A behavior he abandons towards the very end of the film as his true nature is revealed.

Daniel is not below willingly putting himself in submission of his rivals in order to cause them reputational harm and loss of power. Case in point he wound up at church because in order to further maximize his business (and sell his company) he has to build a pipeline to Union Oil, which he cannot do due to a single land hold out, this holdout through a series of events eventually agrees to allow the pipeline through his land on the condition that Daniel gets baptized at Eli's Church. This is a humiliating moment for Plainview as he and Sunday have been clashing heads since they first met. At the church service Daniel seems disinterested even

ignoring Eli's calls on new people who might want to repent their sins (get baptized). However, once Daniel stands to volunteer, in front of the congregation Eli is portrayed biblically by facing up towards the sky as if showing that he is a vessel for God, meanwhile Plainview forced onto his knees by Eli is kneeling outwards towards the audience his head just below the cross behind him, showing him to the congregation as a man below god, repenting. In the setting of the church this shows that Eli is completely in perceived power with Daniel submitting to him. Because of his outward show of unfamiliarity with this power dynamic Daniel is genuinely humiliated and shows disgust that he was coerced into submitting to his rival, he shows this by averting his eyes from the congregation and fuming to himself, however this is something he feels he must do to achieve his goals.

The inner psyche of Daniel Plainview outwardly looks to be breaking shown by his shameful outer shell, a position which a powerful man like himself should be unfamiliar with, but he uses this to entrap his enemy and gain control. Eli throws personal jabs at Plainview by having him repeat and reply to phrases "You have abandoned your child - I have abandoned my child" (Anderson). Eli does this not to dig at Daniel's emotions, but to show the congregation his faults as a self-presented "family man". In reaction to this Daniel recoils and replies in suppressed rage. At this point Plainview realizes why he is there in the first place, he places the personal jabs aside, to realize that the outcome of his submission will hurt his opponent back into submission. In a split second he flips the script, he starts shouting these phrases overly determined making his confession and baptism more believable and submitting any power he still holds to Eli. Plainview looks at the congregation, his facial muscles overcome by passion, shown by sweating and spitting to aid his speech. Eli's reputation is boosted by this making the "exorcism" seem real, Eli plays into this by slapping and forcing Daniel around to affirm his

power. However, for Eli this only means lowering his guards for Plainview's trojan horse of manipulation that is to come.

Daniel is able to keep a level head, keeping his goals in mind. Especially when both of their intentions are somewhat revealed towards the end of their tirades when Eli asks Daniel whether he "…accept[s] Jesus Christ as [his] savior?" to which with a strange tone and resolve Daniel replies "I do!" (Anderson). Plainview confirms that he has the end in sight something that Eli ignored being blinded by emotion and a rush of newfound power, this left Daniel emotion disappeared from Daniel after Eli mentioned his faults as a person, he was able to think ahead and uplay his situation. Water is poured on Daniel to baptize him while a church song plays, which was absent during this discourse, marking an end to the feud. This is reversed by Daniel loudly shaking the water out of his hair, remarking slyly afterwards "that's a pipeline." (Anderson). Daniel stands up to face Eli who now looks vulnerable in stark contrast to the looming figure he was before, Plainview shakes his hand and says something that is drowned out by the music. Leading the audience to realize that Daniel never submitted any power to Eli, and whether he was humiliated at all by this confession. Daniel steps away from the front of the congregation leaving Eli defenseless and irresolute as Daniel is able to walk toward the congregation who accept him with open arms. Eli continues the service broken and Daniel while sat back down is hugged by a little girl, reminding them both of the apparent failures of their ways.

In this scene Daniel Plainview shows that he has clear control of power over his domain, by first willing to be humiliated lacking much of any personal emotion then by use of his cunning personality Plainview uses his drive and greed for success to subvert the control of Eli's power over the public and use it to his benefit to inversely submit his rival. Neither Daniel

Plainview or Eli Sunday is a noble man, they are both driven by greed and a drive to gain power over the other, but Daniel again and again shows his long-term thinking to gain power. The film leaves everyone worse off, but during this converging point of Plainview's confession he shows how he was able to use his wits and charisma to reach success at the cost of people close and far from him. Plainview is not a protagonist, antagonist, or anti-hero, he is a cold hearted businessman, however much he might want to present himself otherwise, dead set on achieving riches in an era where it was possible to excel above and beyond the rest of society.

Works Cited

There Will Be Blood. Dir. Paul Thomas Anderson. Perf. Daniel Day-Lewis and Paul Dano. Ghoulardi Film Company. Paramount Vantage & Miramax, 2008.